THE STONE AGE: PALAEOLITHIC & MESOLITHIC

STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINE → STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL → LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPARED → INDIAN SITE MAP: REGION → MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOP → ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

◆ PRIMARY CORE FLOW ◆ SUBORDINATE EXTRA ◆ APPROVAL / REVIEW

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g14 and all prior artifacts unchanged

00 STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINE

STONE AGE CHRONOLOGICAL-CLIMATIC SPINE · PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE · LOWER PALAEOLITHIC · MIDDLE PALAEOLITHIC · UPPER PALAEOLITHIC · MESOLITHIC HANDAXE/CLEAVER FLAKES/PREPARED CORES BLADES/BONE/ART MICROLITHS MOBILE LANDSCAPES FLEXIBLE · TRANSITIONS ARE REGIONALLY STAGGERED; TOOL CHANGE IS NOT A

PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE → Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared → cores blades/bone/art microliths mobile landscapes flexible reduction wider symbolism diverse niches → Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

CHRONOLOGY / PHASE

- PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE
- Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared

MATERIAL / INSTITUTION

- cores blades/bone/art microliths mobile landscapes flexible reduction wider symbolism diverse niches
- Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

IMPACT / LIMIT

- PLEISTOCENE HOLOCENE
- Lower Palaeolithic → Middle Palaeolithic → Upper Palaeolithic → Mesolithic handaxe/cleaver flakes/prepared

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Transitions are regionally staggered; tool change is not a single species timetable.

01 STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL ARCHIVE

STONE IS A BEHAVIOURAL ARCHIVE · RAW-MATERIAL NODULE · CORE REDUCTION · TOOL USE · DISCARD SOURCE DISTANCE SKILL/PLANNING EDGE DAMAGE ACTIVITY AREA · ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT · BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE · A LABELLED TOOL WITHOUT CONTEXT CANNOT ESTABLISH AGE, SPECIES

RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning → ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE → A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning edge damage activity area
- ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.
- RAW-MATERIAL NODULE → CORE REDUCTION → FLAKE/BLADE → TOOL USE → DISCARD source distance skill/planning edge damage activity area

DEBATE / LEGACY

- ASSEMBLAGE + STRATIGRAPHY + DATING + PALAEOENVIRONMENT → BEHAVIOURAL INFERENCE
- A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: A labelled tool without context cannot establish age, species or complete lifeway.

02 LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPARED

LITHIC SYSTEMS COMPARED · LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC BIFACES, CLEAVERS FLAKE TOOLS BLADES · TECHNOLOGY RECORDS CHOICES; OLDER TECHNIQUES MAY PERSIST BESIDE NEWER · PREPARED-CORE PLANNING BONE/ORNAMENT GROWTH HAFTED COMPOSITES QUARTZITE COMMON RAW-MATERIAL

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools	Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.	prepared-core planning bone/ornament growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses
prepared-core planning bone/ornament growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses	LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools	Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools
- prepared-core planning bone/ornament growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.
- LOWER MIDDLE UPPER MESOLITHIC bifaces, cleavers flake tools blades, burins geometric microliths large cutting tools

DEBATE / LEGACY

- prepared-core planning bone/ornament growth hafted composites quartzite common raw-material economy symbolic evidence bow/sickle/barb uses
- Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Technology records choices; older techniques may persist beside newer ones.

03 INDIAN SITE MAP: REGION, SITE, SIGNIFICANCE

INDIAN SITE MAP · REGION, SITE, SIGNIFICANCE · SOAN VALLEY · RIVER-TERRACE LITHICS AND SEQUENCE DEBATES · BELAN VALLEY · LONG PREHISTORIC SEQUENCE TOWARD FOOD PRODUCTION · SHELTERS/ROCK ART · MESOLITHIC EVIDENCE

NORTH-WEST: Soan valley → river-terrace lithics and sequence debates

NORTH: Belan valley → long prehistoric sequence toward food production → CENTRAL: Bhimbetka → shelters/rock art → Adamgarh → Mesolithic evidence

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- NORTH-WEST: Soan valley → river-terrace lithics and sequence debates
- NORTH: Belan valley → long prehistoric sequence toward food production
- CENTRAL: Bhimbetka → shelters/rock art

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Adamgarh → Mesolithic evidence
- WEST: Bagor → Mesolithic settlement, subsistence and domestication debate
- GANGA PLAIN: Sarai Nahar Rai, Mahadaha, Damdama → burials and sedentism

DEBATE / LEGACY

- SOUTH: Attirampakkam → early Acheulian and Middle Palaeolithic chronology
- DECCAN: Hunsgi-Baichbal → quarry, factory and landscape organisation

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: DECCAN: Hunsgi-Baichbal → quarry, factory and landscape organisation.

04 MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOP

MOBILITY-SUBSISTENCE-SOCIAL LOOP · SEASONAL RESOURCES · MOVEMENT SCHEDULE · CAMP TYPE · TOOL KIT · SHARING NETWORK GAME, FISH, PLANTS BASE/SPECIAL CAMP HEARTHS PORTABLE/COMPOSITE · REPEATED OCCUPATION AND STORAGE MAY INCREASE WITHOUT FULL FARMING · BURIALS SHOW TREATMENT OF PERSONS; RANK NEEDS PATTERNED UNEQUAL

SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game → Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages. → Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game, fish, plants base/special camp hearths portable/composite
- Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages.

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.
- SEASONAL RESOURCES → MOVEMENT SCHEDULE → CAMP TYPE → TOOL KIT → SHARING NETWORK game, fish, plants base/special camp hearths portable/composite

DEBATE / LEGACY

- Repeated occupation and storage may increase without full farming or permanent villages.
- Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Burials show treatment of persons; rank needs patterned unequal evidence.

05 ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC LIFE: INFERENCE LADDER

ROCK ART AND SYMBOLIC LIFE · INFERENCE LADDER · PIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT SECURE · IMAGE, TECHNIQUE, RELATIVE SEQUENCE AND DEMONSTRATED ASSOCIATION PROBABLE · HUNTING, DANCE, GROUP ACTION, ANIMALS AND CHANGING STYLE UNCERTAIN · EXACT MYTH, DEITY, ARTIST IDENTITY OR DIRECT RITUAL MEANING · ART EXPANDS BEHAVIOURAL EVIDENCE BUT IS NOT ILLUSTRATED SCRIPTURE.

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- PIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT secure: image, technique, relative sequence and demonstrated association probable: hunting,
- dance, group action, animals and changing style uncertain: exact myth, deity, artist identity or direct ritual meaning

METHOD / DEBATE

- VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.
- PIGMENT/ENGRAVING + SUPERIMPOSITION + MOTIF + SHELTER CONTEXT secure: image, technique, relative sequence and demonstrated association probable: hunting,

HISTORICAL RESULT

- dance, group action, animals and changing style uncertain: exact myth, deity, artist identity or direct ritual meaning
- VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: art expands behavioural evidence but is not illustrated scripture.

06 MESOLITHIC TRANSITION: ADAPTATION, NOT REVOLUTION

MESOLITHIC TRANSITION · ADAPTATION, NOT REVOLUTION · HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES SMALL GAME/FISH/PLANT NICHES + · UNEVEN PATHWAYS TOWARD NEOLITHIC PRODUCTION

HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools → seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools
- seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools
- seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

DEBATE / LEGACY

- HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools
- seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: HOLOCENE WARMING + REGIONAL ECOLOGIES small game/fish/plant niches + locality + microlithic composite tools seasonal mobility repeated/semi-sedentary camps selective plant/animal management → uneven pathways toward Neolithic production.

07 LIMITS AND CURRENT RESEARCH

LIMITS AND CURRENT RESEARCH · SPARSE FOSSILS + DISTURBED SITES + BROAD TOOL LABELS · FALSE SHORTCUTS · ONE TOOL · ONE PEOPLE · DATE CONTEXTS, RECONSTRUCT REDUCTION SEQUENCE, COMPARE REGIONS, STATE CONFIDENCE · REFINED CHRONOMETRY AND LANDSCAPE STUDY CAN REVISE EARLY DATES. · INDIAN PREHISTORY IS A MOSAIC OF LONG CONTINUITY AND

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- PROBLEM: sparse fossils + disturbed sites + broad tool labels + uncertain associations
- FALSE SHORTCUTS: one tool = one people
- innovation = migration

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- burial = hierarchy
- RESPONSE: date contexts, reconstruct reduction sequence, compare regions, state confidence
- Refined chronometry and landscape study can revise early dates.

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Indian prehistory is a mosaic of long continuity and episodic innovation.

08 STONE AGE ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

STONE AGE ANSWER ARCHITECTURE · 10 MARKS · DEFINE PHASE · DIAGNOSTIC TECHNOLOGY · TWO SITES · 15 MARKS · LITHIC COMPARISON · SYMBOLIC EVIDENCE

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- 10 MARKS: define phase → diagnostic technology → two sites → subsistence → caution
- 15 MARKS: chronology → lithic comparison → ecology/mobility → symbolic evidence → limits

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 20 MARKS: geological frame → methods → four-stage technology → regional site map
- economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict

DEBATE / LEGACY

- MUST DISTINGUISH: relative/absolute date; artefact/assemblage; microlith/sedentism.
- CLOSE: technology records adaptive choices, not a uniform evolutionary ladder.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: economy/social life → Mesolithic transition → historiographical verdict.

09 EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL

EVIDENCE LADDER AND CONFIDENCE CONTROL · EVIDENCE LADDER · FROM SOURCE BOOK · STANDARD KNOWLEDGE · CURRENT AFFAIRS. · 2. ADAMGARH (MP) AND BAGOR (RAJASTHAN) PROVIDE EARLY EVIDENCE · 3. BHIMBETKA IS A KEY ROCK-ART AND PREHISTORIC OCCUPATION · SOURCE TYPE CONTROLS THE STRENGTH AND LIMITS OF THE

SOURCE / MATERIAL	METHOD / DEBATE	HISTORICAL RESULT
EVIDENCE LADDER	2. Adamgarh (MP) and Bagor (Rajasthan) provide early evidence for...	VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.
1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.	3. Bhimbetka is a key rock-art and prehistoric occupation site.	EVIDENCE LADDER

SOURCE / MATERIAL

- EVIDENCE LADDER
- 1. = from source book = inference / standard knowledge = current affairs.

METHOD / DEBATE

- 2. Adamgarh (MP) and Bagor (Rajasthan) provide early evidence for...
- 3. Bhimbetka is a key rock-art and prehistoric occupation site.

HISTORICAL RESULT

- VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.
- EVIDENCE LADDER

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Source type controls the strength and limits of the historical claim.

10 EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES

EXAMINER TRAPS AND CONTESTED BOUNDARIES · CLOSE DISTINCTIONS · 1. B-04 DOMESTICATION AND SAMBHAR CLAIMS WITH CAUTION CARDS · 2. A-06 ROCK ART AND CULT EVIDENCE WITH CAUTION · 3. CONTESTED ISSUES COMPETING INTERPRETATIONS ARE ATTRIBUTED, EVIDENCED · QUALIFICATION EARNS MARKS; FALSE CERTAINTY IS A HARD FAILURE.

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY	EVIDENCE / MECHANISM	DEBATE / LEGACY
CLOSE DISTINCTIONS	2. A-06 Rock art and cult evidence with caution Cards 14 and 19	VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.
1. B-04 Domestication and Sambhar claims with caution Cards 13, 17 and 21	3. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...	CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS
- 1. B-04 Domestication and Sambhar claims with caution Cards 13, 17 and 21

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 2. A-06 Rock art and cult evidence with caution Cards 14 and 19
- 3. Contested issues Competing interpretations are attributed, evidenced...

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.
- CLOSE DISTINCTIONS

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Qualification earns marks; false certainty is a hard failure.

11 INTEGRATED ANSWER SPINE AND QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

INTEGRATED ANSWER SPINE AND QUALIFIED CONCLUSION · ANSWER SPINE · 1. PRACTICE CONTRACT EVERY SOLVED ITEM HAS DEMAND DECODING · 2. [INTERPRETATION] DATING, REGIONALITY, CONTINUITY, DEBATES AND UPSC · 3. METHOD · FACTS FROM SOURCES ARE LABELLED FACT; ANALYTICAL SYNTHESIS IS · CLAIM, NAMED EVIDENCE, ANALYSIS AND QUALIFICATION LEAD TO A

ANSWER SPINE → 1. Practice contract Every solved item has demand decoding, an examiner → 2. [Interpretation] Dating, regionality, continuity, debates and UPSC → 3. METHOD: Facts from sources are labelled FACT; analytical synthesis is → VERDICT: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded

POLITY / ECONOMY / SOCIETY

- ANSWER SPINE
- 1. Practice contract Every solved item has demand decoding, an examiner-...

EVIDENCE / MECHANISM

- 2. [Interpretation] Dating, regionality, continuity, debates and UPSC...
- 3. METHOD: Facts from sources are labelled FACT; analytical synthesis is...

DEBATE / LEGACY

- VERDICT: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded...
- ANSWER SPINE

MECHANISM / VERDICT — VERDICT: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded...

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification lead to a graded.

E SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

EXTRA · OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT · 1. SNAPSHOT & CORE IDEA · 2. KEY CLASSIFICATION · 3. STUDY LINKS · 4. MUST-KNOW FACTS (PRELIMS) · 5. UPSC TRAPS · 6. CURRENT LINK · 7. MAINS ANGLES

OPTIONAL SOURCE DEPTH

- Mini-timeline
- 1. Snapshot & core idea
- 2. Key classification / data
- 3. Study links

ADVANCED DEBATE

- 4. Must-Know Facts (Prelims)
- 5. UPSC Traps
- 6. Current link
- 7. Mains angles

LEGACY / NUANCE

- She discusses Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic sites separately, including tool types and manufacturing contexts.
- Isampur is treated as a centre of stone-tool manufacture.
- Middle Palaeolithic discussions include Attirampakkam and the Levallois technique.
- Mesolithic levels can yield animal bones and pottery; some claims of domesticated cattle, sheep, goat, dog and pig are questioned.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.

END OF MASTER CANVAS • poster embeds this exact master • tiled pages are overlapping crops of the same pixels